

men. In the US at the turn of the 20th century, such living arrangements (between two women, whether romantically involved or not) became known as a “Boston Marriage” due to Henry James’s novel *The Bostonians* (1886), which tells the story of two unmarried, wealthy women living together in the city and having an intimate friendship.

The 20th century brought LGBTQ women out into the open. The 1920s in particular saw many “new women” (see pp. 222–225) have high-profile affairs with men and women alike, and the end of the century saw increasing numbers of female celebrities coming out of the closet. A major factor in these women choosing to live openly was the ongoing struggle for LGBTQ rights, which has been the focus of the gay liberation movement of the 1960s and the subsequent gay rights movement from 1972. While these LGBTQ movements have been criticized for marginalizing women’s voices, they have nonetheless won major rights and protections for all LGBTQ people, including (in many nations) the right to same-sex marriage.



▼ Raising the flag

Women carry rainbow flags (designed by Gilbert Baker in 1978) at the 2015 Pride Parade in Montreal, Canada. Formerly a protest, Pride is now also a celebration of LGBTQ people.



PROFILES

RAINBOW GIRLS

Christina of Sweden (1626–1689) ruled from 1644–1654. Known for wearing men’s clothes and disdaining feminine activities, the queen had a number of male suitors (and female favorites) but refused to marry or produce an heir. When she converted to Catholicism, her councillors took the opportunity to convince her to abdicate her throne. Some historians have since speculated that Christina, confused for a boy at birth, may have been intersex.

Radclyffe Hall (1880–1943) was a British writer known for writing *The Well of Loneliness* (1928), which was banned in Britain until 1949 for its lesbian content. Hall, whose friends called her John, dressed as a man and lived with her partner, Lady Una Troubridge, from the time she was 26 until her death. She identified as a “congenital invert,” inspired by the work of contemporary sexologists.

Lili Elbe (1882–1931) was one of the first transgender women to undergo sexual reassignment surgery. Elbe first dressed as a woman, “Lili,” in 1904 for a portrait for her wife, but soon took up the mantle permanently. She moved from Denmark to Paris to Dresden, where she had pioneering surgeries that allowed her to change her legal sex. After her marriage was voided by the Danish king, Elbe accepted a proposal from a man, but died from an attempted uterus transplant before they could marry.

Marsha P. Johnson (1945–1992) was an African American gay rights activist and leader of the 1969 Stonewall Uprising in Greenwich Village, New York. Later, she and Sylvia Rivera formed the Street Transvestite Action Revolutionaries, a charity for homeless transgender youth. Although Johnson used the term “transvestite,” historians today consider her a transgender woman. She was murdered in 1992.

Ellen DeGeneres (b. 1958) is a comedian, talk show host, and actress, known for being the first openly lesbian woman on prime time television. She came out in 1997 along with her titular character on the sitcom *Ellen*, inspiring generations of women. DeGeneres married the actress Portia de Rossi in 2008.